Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Ezra

Ezra 1:1

- King Cyrus II ruled Persia from 559 to 530 BC. In October 539 BC, Cyrus and his Persian forces conquered Babylon, as Daniel had predicted (Daniel 5).
- the word…through Jeremiah: God promised to bring his people back after seventy years in exile (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10).
- God's influence over this non-believing king led him to issue the following decree (see also Isaiah 13:17; 41:2, 25; Jeremiah 50:9). God remains in control, even when rulers and nations do not acknowledge his authority (Isaiah 10:5, 12–14).

Ezra 1:1–3

The first three verses of Ezra are nearly identical to 2 Chronicles 36:22–23. This suggests a connection between the books.

Ezra 1:2

Although Cyrus mentions the Lord, the God of heaven, he was actually a Zoroastrian. His proclamation, written in Hebrew, was likely political propaganda to gain Jewish support for his rule. In a similar statement to the Babylonians, Cyrus claimed to worship their chief god, Marduk. However, his words here show that God appointed him to build a temple in Jerusalem (see Isaiah 44:28; 45:1, 13). He might have learned about these prophecies from Daniel, who served in his court as a high government official (Cyrus is likely referred to by his Median name, Darius, in Daniel 6:1–28; 9:1). God had long planned to raise up Cyrus and give him a vision to restore worship in Jerusalem (Isaiah 44:28; 45:13; 48:14–15).

Ezra 1:3

Whoever among you belongs to His people…may he go: The Assyrians and Babylonians controlled their empires by moving people and spreading them across cities. In contrast, the Persians sent exiled people back to their homelands. They expected these people to be grateful, obey the Persians, and pay taxes.

Ezra 1:4

Cyrus likely did not urge Babylonian neighbors to help the Jewish remnant. Instead, he encouraged Jews staying in Babylon to assist their countrymen returning to Jerusalem.

Ezra 1:5–6

- As with Cyrus's heart (Ezra 1:1), God inspired Israel's leaders.
- Few priests and Levites responded (see Ezra 2:36–42). Most responders were from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. Persian documents show many Jews stayed in Babylon, where they had homes, businesses, and relatives. A dangerous four-month journey back to Jerusalem, now a desolate city inhabited by foreigners, was not appealing compared to their comfortable life in Babylon. It was easier to give valuable gifts and voluntary offerings to those who returned.

Ezra 1:7

Many items from the Lord's temple had been taken to Babylon (see 2 Chronicles 36:7; Daniel 1:2). By placing these items in his pagan temple, Nebuchadnezzar tried to show his god's power over the Hebrew God. However, God promised the return of all the stolen items (see Jeremiah 27:16–22). The items from the temple were holy utensils, acceptable to God for worship and very valuable to the returning worshipers.

Ezra 1:8

Sheshbazzar was the Persian-appointed governor of Judah who laid the temple's foundation (Ezra 5:14–16). Some believe Zerubbabel (Ezra 3:2, 8) was the same person with a new name (see Daniel 1:7). However, since both names are Babylonian, it is more likely these two leaders worked together on the temple foundation. Zerubbabel probably became governor after Sheshbazzar died.

Ezra 1:9–11

5,400 gold and silver articles: The numbers listed only total 2,499 items. A similar account in the apocryphal book 1 Esdras 2:13–15 lists 5,469 items, while a list by the Jewish historian Josephus in Antiquities 11.15 lists 5,220 objects. Ezra's shorter list shows the types of items included but does not list every item. Keeping track of consecrated utensils helped prevent confusion with pagan utensils used for worshiping other gods.

Ezra 2:1–70

This chapter is Ezra's first major digression from the main story. The returning exiles needed to identify true Jews to maintain their community identity and theological purity. This helped them know whom they could marry and who could worship at the temple. This list is not the initial list of all Jews who returned to

Jerusalem (compare Nehemiah 7:6–73). Instead, it is a slightly later list, created after Sheshbazzar died, of people who had settled in their towns.

Ezra 2:2

Jeshua, a variant spelling of Joshua, son of Jehozadak (Ezra 3:2, 8), from Aaron's lineage, was the high priest (Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 3:1). The Nehemiah mentioned here is not the one who later built Jerusalem's walls. This Mordecai is not the famous relative of Esther.

Ezra 2:3–20

In the ancient Near East, people identified themselves by answering, "Who are your father and your family?" Priests were known as the sons of Aaron. If they could not prove this link, they could not serve (Ezra 2:61–62). Others identified themselves by a well-known elder in their group.

Ezra 2:21–35

the men of…the descendants of: Some returnees were identified by their hometowns. Not everyone knew their family history or had famous ancestors. Most cities mentioned were near Jerusalem.

Ezra 2:36–42

the priests…The Levites: Only seventy-four Levites returned to Jerusalem, which was a very low number. Ezra later worked hard to bring thirty-eight more with him (see study note on Ezra 8:18).

Ezra 2:41–42

- The singers played instruments and sang for worship at the temple (1 Chronicles 25:1–31; Psalms 73–83). The gatekeepers managed the temple gates and storehouses (1 Chronicles 9:26–27; 2 Chronicles 23:19; Nehemiah 12:25).
- Asaph was one of the three Levites King David appointed to lead music at the temple (1 Chronicles 16:5, 7). He wrote a collection of psalms (Psalms 50, 73–83). His family continued his work (1 Chronicles 25:1–7).

Ezra 2:43–54

The temple servants were likely descendants of the Gibeonites (Joshua 9:23–27). They helped the Levites (Ezra 8:20) by carrying water and wood and sweeping floors.

Ezra 2:55–58

- The descendants of King Solomon's servants are linked to the temple servants (Ezra 2:43–54). Their names might show their duties. For example:
- Hassophereth, meaning "the scribe," probably kept inventories
- Pokereth-hazzebaim, meaning "gazelle-hunter," likely hunted game

Ezra 2:59–60

Some returnees believed in Israel's God but lacked genealogical records to prove they were Israelites. Without this information, the other Israelites were unsure whether to treat them as family and intermarry with them or as outsiders. The genealogies in 1 Chronicles 1–9 show how carefully many families kept their histories.

Ezra 2:61–63

they could not find them: The lack of a genealogy was a problem for three families (Ezra 2:61–62). They were excluded from priestly privileges or responsibilities until the high priest received divine guidance through the Urim and Thummim to know God's will (see Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21). Although using the Urim and Thummim was like throwing dice or drawing straws, when done by the priest, the result was a divine decision, not random chance.

Ezra 2:64–66

- 42,360: This number might include children, as it does not match the 28,774 people listed in Ezra 2:3–42.
- The large number of servants and animals indicates that some of the Jews who returned were wealthy.

Ezra 2:68–69

When the tabernacle was built (Exodus 25:2–7; 35:4–9) and the temple was renovated (2 Kings 12:1–21), the people gave voluntary offerings to support the work. These funds added to the provincial grant by Darius (Ezra 6:8) and gifts from Israelites who remained in Babylon (1:6). Each person gave according to his resources.

Ezra 2:69

- Each gold coin, known as a Hebrew daric, was worth a month's wages for a professional soldier.
- 5,000 minas of silver: Each mina weighed 20 ounces and equaled 60 shekels of silver. Each shekel was worth an average worker's monthly wages.

Ezra 3:1

Festivals in early autumn (literally in the seventh month) included the Feast of Trumpets (see Leviticus 23:23–25), the Day of Atonement (see Leviticus 16), and the Feast of Tabernacles (see Leviticus 23:34–36).

Ezra 3:1–4.5

After resettling in various towns in Judah, the community focused on restoring the worship of God in Jerusalem. They quickly rebuilt the altar and began regular sacrifices in time to celebrate the Jewish festivals (Ezra 3:4). Then, they started the more challenging task of rebuilding the temple itself (Ezra 3:8). Soon, they faced opposition from local foreigners (Ezra 4:1–5).

Ezra 3:2

- Jeshua (Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 3:1) was the high priest (Nehemiah 12:1). However, Ezra did not use this title (Ezra 2:2; 3:2; 4:3; 5:2), which suggests the title was given after the temple was completed (6:15).
- Zerubbabel served as the governor of Judah, appointed by Persia (Haggai 1:1), likely after Sheshbazzar died (see study note on Ezra 1:8). He was the grandson of King Jehoiachin of Judah (1 Chronicles 3:17).

Ezra 3:3

- The local residents were foreigners resettled from abroad by the Assyrian king Esarhaddon, who ruled from 680 to 669 BC after the people of the northern kingdom of Israel were exiled in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:24–40). Some had moved into the Jerusalem area during Judah's seventy-year exile. A pagan altar might have been built on the site, and it needed removal before constructing the new one dedicated to the Lord.
- on its foundations: It was important to place the altar at the exact sacred spot where Solomon's altar had been to connect with the authentic worship carried on before the exile in Babylon.
- Daily morning and evening sacrifices (see Exodus 29:38–42; Numbers 28:3–8) dedicated the day to God.

Ezra 3:4

The seven-day Festival of Shelters, as described in the Law (Leviticus 23:33–36; Numbers 29:12–38; Deuteronomy 16:13–16), reminded people of God's guidance and care during the forty years the nation lived in tents while traveling from Egypt to the promised land. This festival was especially meaningful to those who had recently made a similar journey from a foreign land, living in tents as they traveled to the promised land.

Ezra 3:5–6

- The list of sacrifices, offered even before the temple's foundation was laid, showed the people's eagerness to worship God faithfully at every chance. They followed the law's instructions precisely.
- The new moon celebrations occurred on the first day of each Hebrew month. The sacrifices and trumpet blasts reminded the people of God's covenant with them (Numbers 10:10; 28:11–15).
- Voluntary offerings included gifts like money for building the temple (Exodus 35:29; 36:3). The Hebrew term can also refer to peace offerings of meat or bread, eaten to celebrate fellowship with God (Leviticus 7:11–21).

Ezra 3:7

Sidon and Tyre: Few tall and straight trees grew in the dry climate of Judah. Those that had grown in Israel were already cut down. Therefore, they hired skilled laborers from countries with tall trees (see also 1 Chronicles 22:1–5; 2 Chronicles 2:7–16).

Ezra 3:8

- In mid-spring, the dry season began, so workers did not have to deal with mud.
- The second year after they arrived was likely 536 BC. The delay in rebuilding was due to the time needed to transport wood from Lebanon to Jerusalem.
- the rest of their associates…began the work: This showed the unity among the returned exiles. Putting the Levites in charge ensured the work followed God's instructions.

Ezra 3:10–11

- The music at this dedication ceremony was similar to the singing when Solomon first brought the ark into the temple (2 Chronicles 5:12–13). Both events led the worshipers to give praise and thanks to the Lord for his faithful covenant love and goodness.
- as David king of Israel had prescribed: See 1 Chronicles 25:1–7.

Ezra 3:12

Some people cried loudly because they were disappointed that the new temple's foundation was not as impressive as the old one (see Haggai 2:3). Others cried because they were very happy to see the Lord's temple restored.

Ezra 4:1

Judah and Benjamin: Most of the people who returned from exile were from these two tribes of Israel (Ezra 1:5).

Ezra 4:2

King Esarhaddon of Assyria, who ruled from 680 to 669 BC, deported the people of Israel to foreign lands. He relocated other conquered peoples to Israel during King Manasseh's reign in Judah. These foreigners learned about the Lord when they arrived in Israel, but they also continued to worship their old gods (2 Kings 17:27–34, 40–41).

Ezra 4:3

- The main political, religious, and tribal leaders united against the foreigners' proposal. They believed it would introduce idolatrous beliefs. The Jews wanted to avoid repeating their ancestors' mistake of worshiping Canaanite false gods, which led to exile.
- as Cyrus king of Persia has commanded us: See Ezra 1:2–4.

Ezra 4:4

Realizing they could not influence the established Jewish community (Ezra 4:1–3), the foreigners took hostile actions to weaken the Israelites' growing political power.

Ezra 4:5

- The people faced severe consequences for their strict dedication to holiness.
- King Cyrus ruled until 530 BC. Darius (Darius I) became the king of Persia in 521 BC. Construction on the temple restarted in 520 BC and concluded in 515 BC (see Ezra 6:15).

Ezra 4:6–23

These verses discuss later opposition to Jewish rebuilding efforts. They actually relate to events during the reign of:

- Xerxes in 486 to 465 BC
- Artaxerxes I in 465 to 424 BC

However, they are included here because they match the theme of opposition. Chronologically, Ezra 4:6 fits between chapters 6 and 7, while 4:7–23 fits before Nehemiah 1.

Ezra 4:7

- The exact date of these events is unknown. They might have happened around the same time as an Egyptian revolt in 448 BC. This was a few years before Artaxerxes I sent Nehemiah to Jerusalem in 445 BC. If this is true, the enemies of Judah and Artaxerxes likely believed the Jews would revolt like the Egyptians did.
- Aramaic was the international diplomatic language of the Persian Empire.

Ezra 4:9

- Including greetings from important political figures and local ethnic leaders would strengthen the letter's accusations and give it more political impact.
- Judges were trusted court officials familiar with Persian laws.
- Support from people in the Mesopotamian cities of Babylon and Erech, as well as the Persian city of Susa, would make the case against the Jews more convincing.

Ezra 4:10

- Ashurbanipal moved people from other conquered lands into Israel and Aram (see 2 Kings 17:24–41).
- Samaria was once the capital of Israel's northern kingdom.
- The province west of the Euphrates River included Syria, Israel, and Judah.

Ezra 4:11–22

Ezra contains a copy in Aramaic of the letter sent to Artaxerxes and his response.

Ezra 4:13

A tribute was a yearly set tax. Customs were likely sales taxes, and tolls were probably fees for using roads. Earlier rulers had gathered significant revenue from the region (Ezra 4:20; compare 1 Kings 10:14–15).

Ezra 4:14

- because we are in the service of the palace: the Aramaic phrase we eat the salt of the palace meant taking an oath of loyalty to the king.
- The letter's authors said they only wanted to protect the king's honor. However, they actually sought power and political advantage over the Jews.

Ezra 4:15–16

- The Persians had access to Babylonian records, which described Jerusalem's revolts against Nebuchadnezzar (see 2 Kings 24:1–7).
- The claim that the Persians would lose the entire province west of the Euphrates was an exaggeration. The Jews were actually a small minority in that province.

Ezra 4:18

The letter was translated from Aramaic into Persian, which was the king's native language.

Ezra 4:19–20

King Jehoiakim, who ruled from 609 to 598 BC, rebelled against Babylon around 601 BC. King Zedekiah, ruling from 597 to 586 BC, rebelled around 588 BC (see 2 Kings 25:2).

Ezra 4:21

Work on the walls stopped until 445 BC. Nehemiah, who served as Artaxerxes' cup-bearer, received permission to restart the reconstruction (see Nehemiah 2:1–6).

Ezra 4:23

- A military unit likely forced the Jews to stop building and enforced the king's orders. They might have torn down part of the rebuilt wall at this time (see Nehemiah 1:3).
- This verse concludes the parenthetical section that began in Ezra 4:6.

Ezra 4:24

The events in the following verses happened about sixteen years after those in Ezra 4:5.

Ezra 4:24–5.5

Ezra now continues the story of building the temple from 520 to 515 BC.

Ezra 5:1

Haggai first delivered his prophecy on August 29, 520 BC (Haggai 1:1). Zechariah started prophesying about two months later (Zechariah 1:1). The books of Haggai and Zechariah contain their messages (see also Ezra 6:14).

Ezra 5:2

- The Jewish leaders had not led with faith (see Haggai 1:1, 12). Now God's spirit motivated them (Haggai 1:14), and they obeyed by starting their work.
- Zerubbabel and Jeshua play important roles in the books of Haggai and Zechariah.

Ezra 5:3

Who authorized you: Unlike the hostile opposition in Ezra 4, this seems to be a routine check to ensure everything follows official rules.

Ezra 5:5

the eye of their God was on the elders: All credit goes to God's control of events, not to any human leader or prophet. God promised that the ruins would be rebuilt (Isaiah 44:26).

Ezra 5:6

officials: A Persian term for inspectors or investigators.

Ezra 5:6–17

Ezra includes a copy in Aramaic of Tattenai's letter to King Darius. Unlike the letter in Ezra 4:11–16, this letter simply asks if the Jews' actions are valid.

Ezra 5:8

- The title the great God was a Persian way to refer to an important high deity. It does not mean the provincial authorities believed in Israel's God.
- Following the design of Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6:36), builders placed a layer of timber in the walls after every three rows of prepared stones (see Ezra 6:4). This helped reduce potential earthquake damage.

Ezra 5:11

- the God of heaven: The Persians understood this title. It referred to the universal high God, not a minor local deity.
- a great king of Israel: Solomon (see 1 Kings 5–8).

Ezra 5:12

destroyed this temple and carried away the people: See 2 Kings 25:9–17.

Ezra 5:13

a decree: See Ezra 1:1–4.

Ezra 5:14–15

The Jews gave detailed information that the Persians could verify for accuracy (see Ezra 1:7–11).

Ezra 5:16

Sheshbazzar probably started the work, and Zerubbabel completed it (see study note on Ezra 1:8).

Ezra 6:2

- The fortress at Ecbatana, the king's summer home, was about 300 miles northeast of Babylon. This suggests Cyrus wrote the scroll in the summer of 538 BC.
- Media was a mountainous area north of Persia and east of Assyria. The Kurds, descendants of the Medes, now inhabit this area.
- Texts introduced by the term Memorandum were usually summaries listing the main facts of an event for the royal archives (compare Ezra 1:9–10).

Ezra 6:3

- This decree is recorded in Ezra 1:2–4.
- The temple will be ninety feet high and ninety feet wide. The changes suggested in the New Living Translation note would align these measurements with Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6:2, 17, 20). However, the larger measurements here might show the maximum size the Persians would finance.

Ezra 6:4

The royal treasury will cover all expenses. It may seem surprising that the Persians would do this, but it was their usual practice. They did the same at Sais and Elephantine in Egypt, and at Ur in Mesopotamia. This generosity aimed to ensure loyalty to Persia.

Ezra 6:8

The cost is to be paid in full: This action fulfilled God's promise through Haggai (Haggai 2:7).

Ezra 6:10

pray for the lives of the king and his sons: In the Cyrus Cylinder, a Persian account of Cyrus's defeat of Babylon, King Cyrus asks, "May all the gods whom I have returned to their sacred cities ask the Babylonian gods Bel and Nebo daily for a long life for me" (see Ezra 1:1–4).

Ezra 6:11–12

if any man interferes with this directive: Inscriptions and official decrees often included curses on those who went against the king's wishes (see Daniel 2:5).

Ezra 6:15

Israel's second temple was completed about seventy years after Nebuchadnezzar destroyed it in 586 BC. Herod the Great remodeled and expanded this temple during the time of Christ. The temple stood for about 585 years until the Roman army, led by Titus, destroyed it in AD 70.

Ezra 6:17

- a sin offering for all Israel of twelve male goats: This blood sacrifice brought God's forgiveness for unintentional sins, ceremonial uncleanness, or thoughtless wrong acts (Leviticus 4–5). Similar sacrifices were made when Moses dedicated the tabernacle (Numbers 7) and when Solomon dedicated the first temple (2 Chronicles 7:1, 4).
- one for each tribe of Israel: Although most returnees were from Judah and Benjamin (Ezra 1:5; 4:1), people from the priestly tribe of Levi are also mentioned (1:5; 2:40, 70). It is also likely that there were returnees from some of the ten northern tribes of Israel. Even if all tribes were not physically represented, the twelve sacrifices emphasized the desire for God to maintain his covenant relationship with all Israel.

Ezra 6:18

- according to what is written in the Book of Moses: See Exodus 29, Leviticus 8, and Numbers 3. The temple staff followed the organization set by David (1 Chronicles 23–27).
- This verse ends the Aramaic section that started in Ezra 4:8.

Ezra 6:19

The Passover celebration remembers when God spared the firstborn of families who marked their doorposts with blood (Exodus 12–13). This was the first joyous national festival for these people.

Ezra 6:20

purified themselves: They acted according to the law of Moses (see Leviticus 9; Numbers 8; 2 Chronicles 29).

Ezra 6:21

together with all who had separated themselves from the uncleanness of the peoples of the land: The exclu-

sion of foreigners in Ezra 4:1–5 was due to their pagan religious practices, not their ethnicity (see also 9:1–2).

Ezra 6:22

- Passover marked the start of the seven-day Festival of Unleavened Bread (see Exodus 12:15–20; Leviticus 23:6–8). This festival celebrated the unleavened bread eaten when Israel left Egypt.
- the LORD had made: Although Darius I ruled a large empire, God guided him to help rebuild the temple of God.

Ezra 7:1

- Many years later, Ezra arrived in Jerusalem in 458 BC (Ezra 7:7–8), about fifty-seven years after the dedication of the second temple. Ezra had been recording events that occurred before his time, but now he begins to record his own history.
- son: In biblical genealogies, the Hebrew word translated as son often means descendant.
- Seraiah was the high priest under Zedekiah; Nebuchadnezzar executed him in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:18–21).

Ezra 7:1–5

Ezra highlights his authority by listing his genealogy (record of ancestors). He traces his family line through Zadok, who served as priest under Solomon, and back to Aaron, the high priest and brother of Moses (1 Kings 2:35). This genealogy is clearly shortened. It includes only 16 generations from Aaron to about eighty years after the exile, while 1 Chronicles 6:3–15 lists 23 generations from Aaron to the exile in Babylon.

Ezra 7:6

- Ezra came from Babylon, where a large and successful Jewish community still existed.
- The Hebrew word for scribe sometimes means "secretary." It refers to an educated and trustworthy person who copied and explained official documents. Many scholars believe Ezra acted like a "Secretary of State for Jewish Affairs" in the Persian government. However, the focus here is on his role as a scribe, studying and teaching the five Books of Moses.

Ezra 7:9

- Ezra and his group planned to leave Babylon on April 8 but actually departed on April 19, 458 BC (Ezra 8:31). During those eleven days, he organized the group, gathered at the Ahava Canal, searched for more Levites, and declared a fast.
- To cover the 800-mile journey in four months, Ezra's group walked about ten miles per day, five days a week. Ezra knew his success was due to the gracious hand of his God (see also Ezra 7:6, 28; 8:22, 31).

Ezra 7:10

Ezra had three life goals:

1. To study God's word
2. To obey God's teachings
3. To teach the people of Israel

He let God's word change his character and behavior to influence others' lives.

Ezra 7:11–26

In this letter, King Artaxerxes gave Ezra the authority to assess the situation in Jerusalem (Ezra 7:14), offer voluntary gifts to God (7:15–20), acquire supplies and funds from local leaders (7:21–24), and implement legal reforms (7:25–26).

Ezra 7:14

- the king and his seven counselors: The Greek historian Xenophon knew about this council (Xenophon, Anabasis 1.6.4–5). Esther 1:14 lists the names of the seven princes of Xerxes, who was Artaxerxes' father.
- the Law of your God: The word translated as law in this verse is the Aramaic word dath, not the Hebrew torah (Ezra 7:10). This suggests that a Persian wrote this letter (Ezra 7:11–26).

Ezra 7:15

whose dwelling is in Jerusalem: God's temple was in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes likely believed he was helping rebuild the house of Jerusalem's local god (see 1 Kings 8:27; Psalm 24:1).

Ezra 7:16

Like Cyrus (Ezra 1:4, 6), Artaxerxes allowed Jews in Babylon to send voluntary offerings to Jerusalem. A large amount was collected from the king, his council, and Jewish contributors (Ezra 8:25–27).

Ezra 7:21–22

The items listed were usually used as offerings in worship (compare Exodus 27:20; 29:2; Leviticus 2:4, 13; 14:10; Numbers 28:7).

Ezra 7:23

the God of heaven: The Jews used this title for the Lord (Ezra 5:11–12), and Cyrus also used it (1:2). The Persian king likely believed, like others in the ancient Near

East, that each country's god or gods controlled their territory. Artaxerxes did not want to risk angering God and disrupting the peace of his empire by failing to provide the worship God of Jerusalem required (Ezra 7:19).

Ezra 7:24

The tax exemptions for temple workers in Jerusalem were like the peace offerings given to people in other countries.

Ezra 7:25–26

Ezra was to teach God's laws and govern the area where the Jews lived. He followed both God's laws and Persian civil law.

Ezra 8:1–14

This list shows the family leaders who bravely traveled with Ezra to Jerusalem to join the Jewish community. It includes fifteen families represented by 1,515 men. With women and children, the total might have been around 5,000 people.

Ezra 8:15

- The Ahava Canal branched off the Euphrates River near Babylon.
- I found no Levites there: Only a few Levites had come earlier with Sheshbazzar (Ezra 2:40). The reason why so few Levites returned to Jerusalem is unclear.

Ezra 8:16–17

The Hebrew term translated as "men of discernment" refers to those who could interpret and explain the Torah. These men were likely respected for their expertise in Scripture (compare Nehemiah 8:8–9). Ezra tasked them with using their influence to recruit more Levites.

Ezra 8:18

the gracious hand of our God: Ezra, his leaders, and Iddo acted to fix the problem, but God's grace made it possible. Only thirty-eight Levites, including the leaders, and 220 temple servants responded.

Ezra 8:20

David and the officials had appointed them: See 1 Chronicles 24–26.

Ezra 8:21

a fast, so that we might humble ourselves: Ezra saw the need to ask God for protection, safety, and health for 5,000 people walking 800 miles. Robbers might hide in the hills, crossing rivers was dangerous, and people could get sick.

Ezra 8:22

ashamed: Ezra had openly declared his faith in God's power to protect the Israelites on their journey. Asking the king for help now would imply that Ezra doubted God's ability to provide.

Ezra 8:23

fasted and petitioned: In the Old Testament, people often fasted while praying to show their need before God (1 Kings 21:9; 2 Chronicles 20:3; Nehemiah 1:4; Daniel 9:3).

Ezra 8:25

The leaders were responsible for transporting offerings for the temple and sacrifices. Since these gifts were holy and belonged to God (Ezra 8:28), the priests needed to care for them.

Ezra 8:26–27

The Persians and supportive Jews donated a large amount of money. Transporting it without a royal escort was very risky.

Ezra 8:31–32

On the twelfth day of the first month we set out: It took twelve days to organize, encourage some Levites to join, and pray for God's protection. Only then could Ezra lead the people toward Jerusalem (see Ezra 7:9).

Ezra 8:35

sacrificed burnt offerings: Many Jews who came to Jerusalem with Ezra likely offered their first sacrifice. This was probably a moving spiritual experience for them to confess their sins and dedicate their lives to God. For details on the burnt offering, see Leviticus 1.

Ezra 9:1–2

- The events that follow occurred about four months after Ezra arrived (compare Ezra 7:9; 10:9).
- Intermarriage with non-Israelites was risky because Israelites might worship other gods and adopt harmful religious practices (compare Ezra 4:1–5; Deuteronomy 7:1–4).

- the holy seed has been mixed: Literally the holy seed has intermingled itself. Israel was a holy covenant nation (Exodus 19:6) and was not supposed to engage in pagan practices (Leviticus 19:2–4; 20:6–8, 22–26). Therefore, the people were to avoid marrying those who might influence them to adopt such practices. When religious and political leaders married foreigners, they risked leading others astray and damaging Israel's unique identity as a holy people.

Ezra 9:1–10.44

Ezra addressed the issue of marrying idol-worshipping foreigners. The Jewish leaders had permitted this practice, even though the early settlers had promised to stay away from pagan influences (Ezra 4:1–5). Ezra prayed for the nation and assisted those who felt guilty about their sins to correct their actions.

Ezra 9:3

sat down in horror: Compare Genesis 37:34; 2 Kings 22:11; Job 1:20.

Ezra 9:4

The evening sacrifice took place around 3:00 in the afternoon.

Ezra 9:5

Ezra showed humility before God by kneeling. His outstretched hands showed he was asking God for help.

Ezra 9:6

I am ashamed...our iniquities are higher than our heads: Although Ezra did not commit these sins, he identified with his people (see "Community Identity" Theme Note).

Ezra 9:6–15

Ezra's prayer serves as a model for intercessory prayer (compare Nehemiah 1:5–11; Daniel 9:4–19). It involves:

- Confessing sin (Ezra 9:6–7)
- Recalling God's past kindness (Ezra 9:8–9)
- Admitting the people have ignored God (Ezra 9:10–12)
- Acknowledging their unworthiness (Ezra 9:13–15)

Ezra 9:7

- Ezra clearly summarizes Israel's history. The people and their leaders sinned and received deserved punishment.
- From the days of our fathers to this day: The effects of Israel's punishment were still visible in Jerusalem at this time.

Ezra 9:8–9

- God's abundant grace and unfailing love should influence how people respond to him (see Deuteronomy 30:1–5). After all God had done for the remnant, it was shameful they were so quick to betray him.
- grace in the sight of the kings of Persia: Babylon and Assyria had tortured and exiled their enemies (2 Kings 17; 25), but Persia treated exiled people kindly and returned them to their homelands (see Ezra 1:1–3).
- a wall of protection: This phrase refers to God's presence protecting the nation of Judah, not the physical walls of Jerusalem, which Nehemiah rebuilt several years later.

Ezra 9:11–12

Your servants the prophets, saying: God clearly explained what he expected from his people (see Deuteronomy 7:3–4; Malachi 2:10–12). He promised great blessings if they followed his covenant rules (see Leviticus 26:1–13; Deuteronomy 28:1–14; Jeremiah 32:36–33:18; Ezekiel 37:15–28; Hosea 14:1–8).

Ezra 9:14

Would You not become so angry with us as to wipe us out?: The sin of marrying non-believers was so serious that they had no hope of survival if they did not repent.

Ezra 9:15

You are righteous: God is angry with sin because He is just and holy.

Ezra 10:1

Ezra's sincere mourning over his people's sin inspired many to join him.

Ezra 10:2

Shecaniah was the first to bravely admit in public that he had been unfaithful to God. Admitting guilt offers hope for forgiveness of sin.

Ezra 10:3

- A covenant is a binding agreement. In this case, it refers to divorcing pagan wives whom the people of Israel had married inappropriately. By doing this, they would renew their commitment to the Sinai covenant.

- Women usually received custody of their children when a marriage ended (compare Hagar and Ishmael, Genesis 21:14).

Ezra 10:4

this matter is your responsibility: As an expert in the law (see Ezra 7:10), Ezra was responsible for guiding the people to a solution that honored God regarding intermarriage. Since the law of Moses did not provide clear instructions for divorcing pagan wives, Ezra needed to create a plan that aligned with Scripture and was fair to everyone involved.

Ezra 10:5

The solemn oath included a promise to act and a self-imposed curse if the promise was broken (see Ruth 1:16–17; 1 Samuel 14:24–28).

Ezra 10:8

according to the counsel of the leaders and elders: It was reasonable for Ezra to add this exception. Some people might not be able to come to Jerusalem to help settle this matter.

Ezra 10:9

on the twentieth day of the ninth month...the heavy rain: The cold and wet weather made meeting outside uncomfortable.

Ezra 10:15

It is unclear why these four people opposed the plan. They might have wanted a stricter penalty, or perhaps they or their family members did not want to divorce their foreign wives. The fact that there were only four dissenters shows the policy had overwhelming support among the rest of the exiles. Sadly, a few years later, a similar problem of intermarriage with foreign wives created another crisis within the community (Nehemiah 9–10).

Ezra 10:44

some of them had children by these wives: The couples likely married before Ezra returned to Jerusalem. They were not exempt from the decree.